

SCALING A SERVICE BUSINESS WITH AI

Six diagnostics from eleven years of building a tech company in Albania, starting with no money and no idea what I was doing.

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I STARTED WITH NOTHING WORTH WRITING DOWN EITHER

In May 2015 I founded division5 in Albania. I was 23, with no connections, no money, no references and no experience. The plan lasted until the money ran out, which did not take long.

THOUSANDS

of jobs created for young Albanians since then, in a country losing its best people to emigration faster than it can replace them.

Demand eventually outran what we could deliver and we had to hire. **Scaling a service business means recruiting, training, retaining, and tightening process constantly just to hold quality steady while you grow.** By around fifteen people I had still never written down a set of values, and it showed.

So this is not a framework I admired in a book. It is what was left after a decade of discovering, repeatedly, that the thing blocking the company was something that existed only in my head. I got a lot of it wrong first, and I have marked where.

How to use it

Six diagnostics, in order. Each ends with something to write. A diagnostic you answer in your head is one you will flatter yourself through, so give it an hour and a pen.

THE BOTTLENECK HAS YOUR NAME ON IT

Every service business has one constraint that everything else queues behind. In most of them it is a person, and in most of those it is the founder. This is not a character flaw. It is what happens when a business grows out of one person being good at something.

The test is not how busy you are. Busy is easy to mistake for essential. The test is **what stops when you stop.**

WRITE THIS ONE DOWN

List every decision from the past week that could not have happened without you. Beside each, mark which of the three it was.

C only you had the context **A** only you had the authority **S** only you had the skill

Now count them. Context can be written down, usually in an afternoon. Authority can be handed over, and the fear of doing so is almost always larger than the cost. Skill is the only one that needs hiring or training.

Most founders find their list is overwhelmingly context. It is the cheapest of the three to fix and the one nobody fixes, because writing things down feels like it is not the job. Training people who had never held a job before removed that option for me, which turned out to be the most valuable thing that ever happened to the company.

RE-SORT EVERY RECURRING TASK

Take the recurring work of the business and put each piece in exactly one of three buckets. Not where it sits today. Where it belongs now.

01

Only you

Judgement, relationships, taste, and the calls that carry real consequence. This bucket is smaller than your calendar implies.

02

Anyone trained

Process with a right answer. If you can describe how it should go, it does not need you, it needs writing down once.

03

Software, now

Pattern work over data you already hold. Drafting, summarising, sorting, checking, first passes of almost anything.

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The trap

Bucket three grew enormously in two years. Almost nobody re-sorted. A list made in 2023 is now wrong.

THE ONLY QUESTION THAT MATTERS HERE

Which tasks did you put in bucket one purely because you have always done them, and not because they genuinely need your judgement? Name three.

WHAT ACTUALLY CHANGED, AND WHAT DID NOT

What changed. The cost of a competent first draft fell to roughly nothing. Every process that begins with one, and most do, now starts much further along. Proposals, research, reports, job specifications, code scaffolding, meeting notes, first replies.

What did not. Someone still has to decide the draft is right, and they need enough context to know when a confident answer is wrong. Remove that person and you produce plausible nonsense at industrial speed.

Where to actually put it

01 Find the processes that start with a blank page

Those are where the gain is largest and the risk is lowest, because a bad draft is visibly bad and costs nothing to discard.

02 Keep a person on the judgement step, permanently

Not as a temporary safeguard until the tool improves. The judgement step is the job now, and it is worth paying more for than the drafting ever was.

03 Measure time to first usable draft

Not accuracy scores, not tokens, not how impressive the demo felt. Time to something a person can work with is the number that shows up in margin.

BE SPECIFIC

Name one process that starts with a first draft and still takes a person more than an hour. That is your first candidate, not the thing you saw in a demo.

THE ORDER IS THE WHOLE THING

Almost every failed attempt I have seen, including two of mine, failed on sequence rather than technology.

01 Write down how the work actually happens

Including the workarounds nobody admits to in a meeting. This is the step everyone skips and it is the step that decides the outcome.

02 Get the data into one clean place

One version of each client, each project, each number. Software cannot act on what it cannot see, and it cannot see across four spreadsheets.

03 Build the system people actually work in

Shaped around how the team already operates, not a template you bend the business into.

04 Only now, automate

At this point it is close to easy, which is the tell that the first three steps were the real work.

Start at step four and you get the pilot that demos beautifully and changes nothing. That is not a technology failure. It is a sequencing one, and it is expensive because it also teaches everyone that this does not work.

LOCATE YOURSELF

Which of the four steps is your business actually on right now, for the process you most want to fix? Write the step number and one sentence on why you are certain.

WHEN WORD OF MOUTH RUNS OUT

Referral is not a growth channel. It is a ceiling with good manners. It arrives when it arrives, it reflects work you did nine months ago, and you cannot turn it up in the quarter you need it.

For years I read a full pipeline as evidence the business was healthy. It was evidence that the last two years had gone well, which is a different and much less useful fact.

What actually produced it was not a tactic. Business gets described as a shark tank and I have never found that true. **Kindness is not softness, it is leverage.** Clients are used to being treated as revenue and to suppliers who retreat behind the contract when something goes wrong. Owning a mistake before they find it is what compounds. A satisfied client pays the invoice. A client who trusts you brings you the next three.

COUNT THEM HONESTLY

Where did your last ten clients come from? Write the actual source, not the category you would put in a deck.

If eight or more are referral, you do not have a growth problem yet. You have a growth risk, which is worse, because it stays invisible until the quarter it is not.

CULTURE IS WHAT CARRIES ALL OF IT

In a service business the systems are people, which is why culture stops being a soft topic and becomes operational.

In mid 2020, right after lockdown, demand jumped and we needed to hire fast. We were around fifteen people and had never written down a set of values. Under about ten you shape culture directly through your own behaviour. Past that your influence thins out faster than you notice.

So I defined some, and I got it wrong. I focused on the social side of culture and lost sight of the business side. It took a couple of years going the wrong direction before I started over and built it around what clients actually valued instead of what made the office pleasant. Those are not in tension. Good results are a large part of why people feel good about their work.

01

Trust

Both directions. If I do not trust your work we cannot work together, and if you do not trust my decisions you cannot follow them.

02

Responsibility

Ownership of the outcome, not just of the task.

03

Accountability

A willingness to be measured against what you said you would do.

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The new problem

If software does the work juniors used to do, the path that produced your seniors is gone. Hire for judgement earlier and pay for it.

THE UNCOMFORTABLE ONE

If your best person left tomorrow, how much of what they know exists anywhere other than in their head?

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Nothing here requires buying anything, which is deliberate. The buying decision gets much easier once these are done, and much cheaper.

01 Weeks one and two

Complete diagnostics one and two, in writing. You are looking for the tasks in bucket one that do not deserve to be there.

02 Weeks three to six

Take the largest context item from diagnostic one and write it down properly, once, so somebody else can act on it. Hand it over and resist taking it back the first time it is done differently to how you would have.

03 Weeks seven to ten

Pick one process from diagnostic three. Map it, clean the data it depends on, and only then look at tools. Expect the cleaning to take longer than the building, because it will.

04 Weeks eleven and twelve

Build one source of new work that is not referral. One. Chosen because you can sustain it, not because it is fashionable.

Ninety days of this beats two years of pilots, and I say that as someone who ran the two years of pilots first.

TWO OF THESE I ENDED UP BUILDING COMPANIES AROUND

Not every problem on this list needs a supplier, and I would rather say which is which than pretend otherwise.

division5

For when the constraint is people. A staffing marketplace connecting vetted AI-native engineers across the Balkans with companies in Europe and beyond. The vetting is worth something because of the decade described in this document.

division5.co

divisionAI

For when the constraint is that the business runs on people remembering things. One system shaped around your processes, with the automation added in the order set out in diagnostic four. divisionai.co

Neither of them fixes diagnostic one. If the honest answer there is that the context lives in your head, no supplier can solve that for you, and anyone who says they can is selling. Write it down first. That part is yours.

If you work through these and get stuck on one, write to me and tell me which. I read everything, and the stuck ones are how I learn what to write next.

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